



a life-threatening incident and he has returned the favour by praying at every major temple in the country ever since, possibly explaining his nation-wide appeal and God-like status. **B** is also for **Baksheesh**, the palm grease that is the required lubricant for getting ahead in life. It also helps raise the living standards of millions of cops, politicians, contractors and bureaucrats. It also is for **Black Label**, without which your social status in India is zero.

**C** is for **Chaat**, the ubiquitous spicy roadside snack and the great Indian leveller. Everybody, CEO to commoner, gathers round their friendly neighbourhood chatwallah in culinary camaraderie, proving that *golgappas* are more binding than most other symbols of patriotism. Also for **Cricket**, the only sport that has a national following except following a series of defeats or defeat in a series, as is evidenced by the sight of products actually being endorsed by non-cricketers. Also stands for **Cow**, that animal held in such reverence. The original sacred cow, it explains why there are more bovines on our roads than cars.

**D** is for **Dosa**, that crispy south Indian specialty that has acquired an all-India fan following and rivals any other cuisine in popularity and availability. In the process, it has made vegetarianism a palatable alternative. **D** is also for **Dhaba**, the highway eatery that serves such robust fare, even if some dishes may taste like they are cooked in axle grease.

**E** is for **Effluent**, the stuff that is discharged into our rivers with unceasing regularity, making them among the most polluted in the world. Also for **Eh!**, that crude exclamation which means nothing but is used by all Indians as a substitute for 'what' or 'whatever'? It may sound more like an abuse than a query, yet it continues to dominate our conversations from Kashmir to Kanyakumari.

**F** is for **Fireworks**, the kind that made Sivakasi famous and have turned most Indians into closet arsonists. We set them off on every possible occasion, from winning elections, to marriages and (male) births, cricket victories to festivals. Fire, of course, is a potent Vedic symbol which explains our agnostic fixation with the big bang or, for that matter,

anything going up in smoke.



**G** is for **Gold**, the stuff that every Indian covets and hoards like, well, gold. Indians are the biggest buyers of gold in the world since an individual's personal wealth is determined not by money in the bank or under the bed, but the gold they have stashed away. The glitter will never fade. Also for **Graffiti**, the "Bunty Loves Bubli" type inside a heart, which is scrawled across our historical monuments and heritage buildings. Defacing public property is a national time pass for lovers who confirm the adage that like love, ignorance is bliss.



**H** is for **Hinglish**, that hybrid of Hindi which is not just peculiar, but peculiar to India. Hinglish translates phrases directly from Hindi, like "slowly-slowly", or words like "pre-pone" or the classic "full and fed up". India is the only country where people "air-dash" to their destination. As they say, we are like that only. **H** is also for the **Headshake**, another uniquely Indian practice which entails shaking one's head from side to side when the headshaker is actually conveying a 'yes', a habit that causes considerable bewilderment and confusion when in conversation with foreigners.



**I** is for **Indian-Chinese**, that culinary bastardisation that adapts Chinese cuisine to Indian tastebuds by adding Indian spices and curry. From Bangalore to Bhatinda and Barabanki, millions of "Chinese" restaurants with Indian or Nepali cooks churn out a unique variation of Chinese dishes. Mao may have said, "Let a thousand cauliflowers bloom..." although he never dreamt that they would be used to create dishes called Chowmein or Chicken Manchurian, which no Chinese worth his ajinomoto would touch with a chopstick.



**J** is for **Jugaad**, or quick-fix improvisation, in which any kind of machinery or motor part can be made to work by using any material that comes to hand, including chewing gum. In politics, used to describe an artful compromise or as precursor to toppling an elected government. Also stands for **Joint Family**, which is not a hippie com-

